

Epilogue

Deep within the bowels of Hell...

There was no sky.

Only darkness.

Darkness broken by rivers of fire that flowed without beginning or end.

Sulphur drifted endlessly through the air.

The ground itself seemed alive, breathing heat upward through endless cracks in blackened stone.

The cries never stopped.

Thousands.

Perhaps millions.

Bodies twisted together in an endless sea of suffering.

Some wept.

Some screamed.

Some simply stared into nothing, having long since exhausted every other response.

Time had no meaning there.

Neither did hope.

High above the writhing masses...

Something moved.

It had no shape that the human mind could comfortably comprehend.

Not smoke.

Not shadow.

Not flesh.

A presence.

Dark.

Patient.

Ancient.

It drifted silently over the countless souls below.

Searching.

Watching.

Waiting.

One by one it passed over forgotten faces.

Kings.

Beggars.

Soldiers.

Children.

The famous.

The forgotten.

Every life eventually became indistinguishable beneath eternity.

Still...

It searched.

Long after any mortal mind would have surrendered...

It stopped.

One body slowly rolled onto its back.

Its eyes were open.

Empty.

Without recognition.

Without memory.

The dark presence hovered above it.

Motionless.

As though confirming something.

Then...

It descended.

Without sound.

Without violence.

Like smoke finding an open doorway.

The darkness entered the lifeless body.

Nothing happened.

For a long moment...

Nothing.

Then...

A finger twitched.

Color slowly returned to pale skin.

Gray gave way to flesh.

Cold lips drew a first shallow breath.

The empty eyes blinked once.

Then again.

Black.

They were black and empty.

The man inhaled sharply as though surfacing from impossibly deep water.

He looked upward into the endless darkness.

Confused.

Alive.

His lips parted.

A single name escaped them.

Silence answered.

Far above...

The fires continued to burn.

The screams continued to echo.

The darkness drifted onward.

Already searching again.

The man slowly pushed himself upright.

He had no idea where he was.

Or why.

He only knew his name.

Mario Saltine.

Alive again.

The Saltine reborn.